

Handout Thurs.
night
read before go to bed

Chapter 10 Sources of information

"Mirror, mirror on the wall, who is the fairest one of all?" asks Snow White's wicked and malignant stepmother.

"To be or not to be?" Hamlet asks himself the essential question.

"What, will these hands ne'er be clean!?" pleads Lady Macbeth to the universe.

Who will take me to the ball?" Cinderella waits for someone to take care of her.

Each of these questions is of passionate interest to the individual involved. Most of us find ourselves wrestling with equally weighty issues and making everyday decisions about them. These decisions affect our lives and everyone else's. Where and how do we obtain the best information necessary to make our choices clear? This chapter is about many sources of information available to us.

Information within us

We have three very powerful sources of information within us which we can sum up as: our head, our heart and our soul.

Our "head"

Our "head" is like a computer in our brain. It contains every experience of our past — everything we have ever learned. The data are stored in orderly files ready to access and apply. Our head is programed to respond to incoming stimulation by supplying the appropriate reference file of information. For example we do not need to learn to drive every time we want to use a car because our head has that information stored about. Our

head is essential for things like that: how to write a check, diaper a baby or do our taxes. It can also access memories and words to songs, put thoughts together to form complex sentences and recreate our multiplication tables. It is our automatic pilot. We would be lost without it.

When it comes to our present relationships, however, our heads are not a useful and dependable source of information. We were programed in our childhood to see things according to our original belief systems and our head continues to do that, even though the situation in the present is not the same. For example if you believed in childhood that being isolated was safer than being vulnerable, your head will interpret overtures of love as a threat. And it will be certain that the threat is real. It does that through its analysis of the situation. Everything is filtered through the same beliefs.

If we live mainly by the information we receive from our heads, and many people from western cultures do, we are likely to interpret all our new experiences according to our belief systems.

We interpret everything that now happens according to what has already happened. The only experience we can value is one that is acceptable to our heads. It is hard to learn any new information about ourselves because everything has to fit the existing system. It is rare to have a new file open. Operating from our head can limit us to living a monochromatic life.

EXERCISE: For an example of information from your head, ask your head right now why you are reading this book. Look up while you ask the question. (Write down the answer.)

Our "heart"

Another source of information is the "heart". This term has been used metaphorically as the centre of human emotions for hundreds of years. The "heart" can be regarded as the source of our experience of what is happening *now*. It is not programed by the past. In fact its information is often wildly different than what

our head's information tells us. Our "heart" tells us how we are feeling, what we want, and what we are experiencing right now. It is a moment-by-moment present-time source of information. It is easy to access! To find out what your "heart" has to say, all you need to do is ask it something. At first it helps to focus your attention inward toward your "heart area" when you are asking a question. And *it is critical to accept the first answer you get.* Information from the heart can often be surprising and your head may well want to argue.

For example, our heart may miss a friend and want to ring her up right now. And our head may say, "No, no. It's too late to call her now, she's probably asleep." Our head is operating on the belief that it is safer to see it as wrong to bother people after a certain time of night.

EXERCISE: Let us test our heart's Information. Ask your heart why you are reading this book and look down. Take the first answer. Remember what your head said? Are the answers the same?

If you would like more practice in head/heart answers, here is an exercise:

Ask the following questions of both your head and heart; write down the answers you get:

- Why do you have the job that you do?
- What do you most want from the person you are with? Or
- Why are you not in a relationship?
- What would you most like to change about yourself?
- What would make you the happiest?

Without information from our hearts we would be automatons. We would be robots.

Our soul

Our souls provide us with the deepest source of information about ourselves — our purpose and, our core values. It is the backdrop, the stage upon which we design our lives. We become aware of it through our lives in many quiet moments, or whenever we really ask for guidance. Our core values are formed deep in our souls and are directly related to our purpose. Living according to our core values is truly being in integrity and creates joy. Not living according to our core values produces guilt. There is a world of difference between our heart and our soul. Whereas our heart can respond from an illusionary voice, our soul is always in integrity. We just have to be willing to commit to living that way.

True guilt is a message from our souls to *change our behavior, right now*. Some people call it the "voice of conscience." It comes on its own, whether we are searching our souls about that behavior or not. Whenever we behave in ways that are not in keeping with our core values, we experience true guilt. This does not have anything to do with punishment or shame. In fact, self-punishment will inhibit the message from our awareness. True guilt demands that we immediately correct our behavior so that we have self-respect and stay on course for our purpose. For example whenever we treat a child harshly, lie to a friend or fail to keep our agreements, we will feel guilty. When this guilt occurs, it is a physical sensation. We can depend on it.

False guilt happens in our heads and is about getting caught and being punished. We have it programed in from all the times we

were punished as a child for a particular sort of behavior, like using "bad" language.

When we do not listen to *our soul's* message to change our behavior, we lose self-respect. Carried to an extreme, our refusal to correct our behavior turns into self-punishment and the punishment *seems* to atone for not changing our behavior — for example "If I feel bad enough about this it's okay to keep doing it". This is a dangerous course of action because the damage to our self-respect from not living according to our core values is such that we will keep sending ourselves stronger and stronger messages to get our own attention. We may eventually create a crisis like disease, divorce, bankruptcy and so on.

Peg: One time I thought I was in love with someone other than my husband and that I wanted to leave my marriage. I was sure that this was what I wanted and that my husband was a jerk. I had it all planned. I was going to tell him while we were on vacation that I was leaving him as soon as we got back. But I couldn't do it. I mean that literally. Every time I prepared to say it my throat would close, I would get dizzy and I would feel tremendously guilty. My heart knew I truly loved my husband, that I was just hurt and angry and not wanting to feel that.

My head thought I should leave and go with this guy who seemed to be so much more what a husband should be. And I wanted to

blame the mess my relationship was in all on my husband. Not only that, I had witnesses to prove that I was right about him!

***My heart** told me to stay and be responsible in my marriage so that I could get off the cycle of failed relationships in my life. And it knew I truly loved my husband, that I was just hurt and angry and not wanting to feel that.*

***My guilt** was slowing me down long enough so that I would pay attention to what my soul was trying to tell me. At the time it wasn't clear to me. All I knew was that I felt crazy and would not leave my husband.*

Most decisions come out of emotions. Even though we think we are making decisions from our rational, logical selves, we are not. The heart is always involved even if we are not aware of it. In fact people who are the most cerebral, are the most controlled by their emotions because their emotions go underground and unconsciously rule the roost.

Roger was the oldest child of a large family when his father died. He became the "man of the family" at twelve. His mother relied heavily on him.

Later as an adult, he worked for a large commercial airline company that was taken over by a man whose management practices were ruthless and alienated a large number of the company's employees.

Some of the disgruntled employees left and started their own company. Roger became its Chief Executive Officer. He was a very intelligent, capable man but the airline did not succeed — partly because of Roger's resentment of his old boss and partly because some of his decisions were made by the 12-year-old boy whose father had died. His unconscious need to do everything alone, to take care of his "family" took precedence over his conscious intention to do whatever was necessary to create a successful company. Roger was not aware of either of these influences on his decision-making processes.

Integrating the information from our heads, hearts and souls leads to clarity in our decisions and choices and power in our personal lives.

Make sure you allow time and space to hear all your messages and to learn from all of them.

Information outside us

There are three major sources of information outside us: support from others, mass consciousness and universal consciousness.

Support from others

Support from others is important when we have decided to make a change in our lives and our fear of and resistance to that change is threatening enough to stop us changing. The feelings we experience during change are so uncomfortable that we will do anything to make them stop: pretend that we have already done it or that we do not really want to do it or that someone else is making us do it. It is then that the support of other people, who are aware of what we decided to change, is essential. Their job is to remind us of our choice, and to tell us the truth about what they see us doing.

Peg: When I decided to be responsible in my relationship with my husband, I hated a lot of what I discovered about myself. For instance I wanted my way all the time and would throw a fit if I didn't get it and that's what I always accused him of! I didn't like to see things like that about myself because it was so uncomfortable. When I was making this change to be personally responsible, I needed my friends to tell me how they saw me acting in the relationship and to remind me that I chose to go through this for my own self-respect and freedom. This helped me to not blame and to stay on course. It was important that they be totally honest with me because if they had said something to make me feel better it would not have helped. It was important for me to ask only those people for support who would be equal with me and not try to take care of me.

Usually the greater the changes we desire, the greater our resistance. We may want to fight the support our friends give us.

Judith: A group of participants recently told me how they saw me handling a personal life situation. My defences got so strong that I was very tempted to pull rank and act like a teacher. It was so

difficult for me to hear what they were really saying. Instead I took a deep breath and dove in. I appreciate their courage.

We need to take what others say to us into our hearts and let their words affect our feelings. And it is not easy. It is a gift to ourselves. We need to take in what others say to us and experience it without either acting on it or discarding it. When our way of thinking is challenged we go into our survival mode and our position gets stronger and more intense.

Killing the messenger is not wise.

To take support that goes against our way of thinking feels like dying and it is. It is the death of an old pattern. When that really happens, there is a physical effect. The dense particles from the suppressed feelings from the old belief systems leave. It is a time when we may get sick.

To give support to someone else means always treating them equally. It means speaking our truth no matter how much we fear doing so. We allow ourselves to have our experience and everyone else to have theirs. It also means we do not offer support to anyone who has not asked for it. There is no reason to sacrifice ourselves.

Peg: Judith and I used to go around giving support to everyone, whether they asked for it or not. It was a big mistake! People got angry at us and always expected that we would tell them what to do. We finally learned to mind our own business, unless someone asked us.

Support is treating as equal beings everyone who is choosing their own life.

Mass consciousness

Mass consciousness is the conglomerate of beliefs and thoughts of our families, our culture and of humanity in general. It is like having radio signals aimed at our heads all the time and it affects us whether we are aware of it or not. Those radio signals vibrate in us like feelings except they vibrate in our heads, not our bodies.

There are patterns of behavior that are associated with different roles in this conglomerate and unless we consciously choose something else we will operate in these patterns because their pull is very strong and familiar. This mass consciousness has patterns for raising children, running a business, fighting a war, loving and everything else we do in our lives. For example there is a pattern associated with marriage. When we decide to get married that pattern clicks in and we start to treat ourselves and our lovers differently than we did before marriage. We stop seeing them clearly and start to see "husband" and "wife" instead. In the mass consciousness a "husband" is supposed to make money and provide for the "wife" and "children" and know about the world. A "wife" is supposed to cook, clean, take care of the "husband's" emotional and physical needs, raise the "children" and sometimes bring in additional income. People hurt themselves and their relationships trying to fit into this pattern even when what they really want to have in their marriages may be something totally different. Some wives make more money than their husbands. Some husbands would rather stay home with the kids and are better suited than their wives to do so.

Universal consciousness

Universal consciousness is another kettle of fish entirely. It is not created by the human mind, but originates in the combined soul of all that is. Some people refer to their originator as God. Others call that information their higher self or inner voice. This consciousness is the universal source of information about *what is so*, without judgement. There is no judgement involved. This source of information is not accepted as true by most of us. Into this realm taps telepathy, precognition and intuition, just knowing something is so without any logical explanation for it. The way to tap into this information is through personal responsibility and unconditional love. The context for universal consciousness is personal responsibility and unconditional love. Did you ever think about someone and have them ring you up just as you were thinking of them? Or know something was going to happen just before it did?

How does that happen? It is not always random or coincidental. You have switched radio stations momentarily. You have tuned into the universal consciousness station.

Universal consciousness always creates the biggest picture. It is where science and mysticism begin to merge. The inspiration that we call genius taps into universal consciousness. Copernicus, Aristotle and Einstein tapped that source for their genius and

inspiration. It is how we know that loving ourselves and treating our bodies with respect will affect the environment of the planet. It is how inner peace creates global peace.

Anyone can tune into universal consciousness if heads and hearts are connected. We have a direct line and it is effortless. How do we know if a piece of information comes from universal consciousness? When our heads and hearts are integrated, the information we receive will feel true and make sense. Then it is a good idea to test it. After a while you will know from how your body feels.

Tapping into the universal source of information is easier than we might think and we all have had experiences with it. We may have discounted the information, however, because it did not match what our heads told us or because we felt too uncomfortable.

Peg: I love to see shooting stars. One night I was walking down my road in the country hoping to see some. I had heard there

were to be meteor showers that night. I saw one fairly dim one and was on my way home when I "knew" that I should turn around and wait. I did and within a minute I saw a gorgeous shooting star.

EXERCISE: Remember the times that you have just known something was going to happen and it did, or some other instances of "knowing". Remember any times that you "knew" something and you ignored it. What was the result

Unknowing things can be as mundane as knowing when the traffic light will change, where to find a parking spot, or that there is a speed trap around the bend. It can be as useful as knowing who to trust in a business deal or when the weather is going to turn. And sometimes it can save your life.

A woman named Katherine had a grandmother who was scheduled to fly up to visit her on a particular flight. The grandmother called her and told her that she was changing to a later flight because she had a nagging feeling that the earlier flight was not a good idea. She was embarrassed but decided to trust her intuition. The original plane crashed and there were only a few survivors.